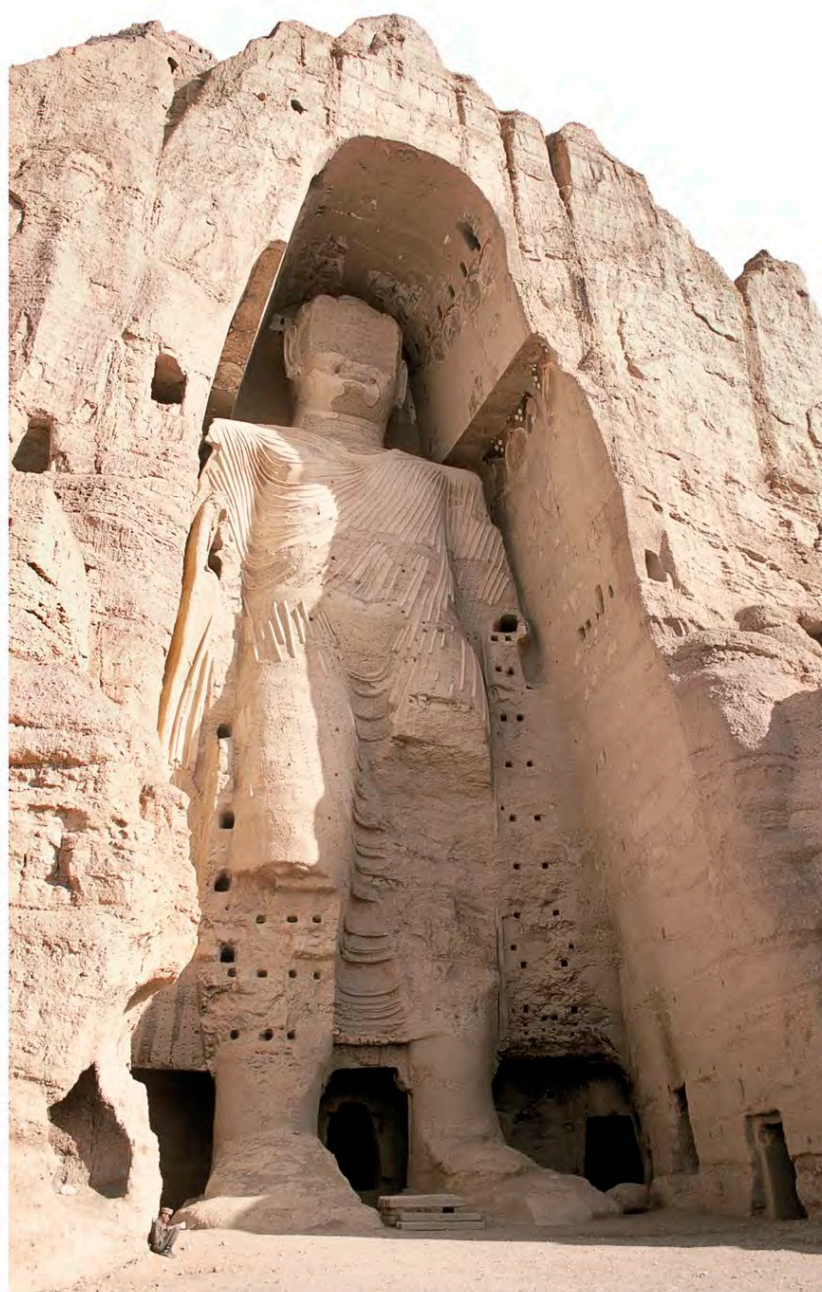




▲ ONE OF THE TWO MASSIVE BUDDHAS AT BAMIIYAN

Wofo Temple

Location Beijing, China

The Wofo Temple—also known as the Wofosi Temple or the Temple of the Sleeping (or Recumbent) Buddha—was originally constructed between about 626 and 629 CE but has been rebuilt many times. As its name suggests, the temple is most famous for its statue of a Buddha reclining as he awaits his *nirvana*—the state of perfect enlightenment. Originally a sandalwood sculpture, it was replaced during the Yuan

dynasty (1279–1368) by a colossal bronze version, more than 17 ft (5 m) long, which is said to have been cast from some 275 tons (250 tonnes) of bronze by several thousand workers.

Giant Buddhas, Bamiyan

Location Bamiyan, Afghanistan

The two soaring Buddhas carved into the sandstone foothills of the Hindu Kush mountains at Bamiyan, central Afghanistan, were

the largest stone statues in existence until 2001, when they were destroyed by Taliban fighters, who declared them to be false gods. Probably created in the 6th to 7th centuries, the spectacular monuments—125 ft (38 m) and 180 ft (55 m) tall, respectively—flanked the numerous rock-cut Buddhist cave monasteries (3rd to 5th centuries) that stretch for around 4,265 ft (1,300 m) along the base of the ochre-colored cliff-face. It is thought that the folds in the Buddhas' robes may have been created by hanging thick ropes from the rocks and then covering them in plaster.

Great Mosque of Damascus

Location Damascus, Syria

The Great Mosque of Damascus, also known as the Umayyad Mosque, is the world's oldest surviving stone mosque. A spectacular example of early Islamic architecture, it was built between 705 and 715 CE by the Umayyad caliphate. It is rectangular in layout, measuring 515 ft by 328 ft (157 m by 100 m), and has two main parts: an open courtyard surrounded by arches and a prayer hall and sanctuary with three aisles formed by arches. The building includes notable features of mosque architecture, such as the *mihrab* (prayer niche), the *minbar* (pulpit), the semicircular (horseshoe) arch, the square minaret, and the *maqsūrah* (a box or screen near the *mihrab*).

Seokguram Grotto

Location Gyeongju, South Korea

Seokguram is a Buddhist cave temple in the form of an artificial grotto constructed of large granite blocks. Built between 751 and

774 CE, during the Unified Silla period (676–935 CE) of ancient Korea, it is located on the upper slopes of the holy Mount Tohamsan and looks eastward over the sea. It comprises an antechamber, a corridor, and a domed rotunda. Inside the inner chamber is a 11-ft- (3.5-m-) tall monumental statue of the Buddha, seated on a lotus pedestal and surrounded by an entourage of exquisitely carved reliefs, including bodhisattvas, disciples, and divine guardians. The grotto, with its sculptures, is an exceptional example

